

Will Sanford, RHP, Oregon

2026 Stats: 3.74 ERA/1.221 WHIP/84.1 IP/126 K/46 BB/2.74 K:BB

6-0, 202

Metrics

FB: 93.4/21.5 IVB/9.4 HB/-3.89 VAA/6.5 ext/5.7 relH/37.4 AA/36% zone/63.4% usage/2470 rpm

CB: 76.3/-18.5 IVB/-9.7 HB/-10.11 VAA/32.9 AA/26.4% zone/24.6% usage/2790 rpm

SL: 83.1/-2.8 IVB/-5.9 HB/-7.79 VAA/27.1 AA/31.7% zone/8% usage/2740 rpm

CH: 84.9/1.6 IVB/15.1 HB/-6.99 VAA/26.2 AA/19% zone/3.9% usage/1440 rpm

Write-up

Will Sanford emerged as the breakout ace for an Oregon club that hosted a regional, reached the Austin Super Regional, and advanced to the Big Ten Tournament Championship Game in 2026. Despite a smaller frame, he possesses one of the premier fastball/curveball combinations in the draft class, supplementing it with a developing slider against right-handed hitters and a hard downer changeup against lefties. The stuff is comfortably that of a professional starter, but the command remains the separator. Sanford walked at least one batter in every outing and issued three or more walks in 10 of his 17 starts, largely due to stretches where the fastball scattered around the zone. If the strike throwing takes a step forward, the arsenal has mid-rotation upside. If not, the power fastball/curveball pairing still gives him a clear path toward a high-leverage bullpen role.

Sanford's fastball is probably the best starters heater in the class sitting 93-95 with an absurdly low -3.89 VAA and 21.5 inches of ride. That combination was lethal this year, garnering a 30% whiff and 14% SWSTR and 134 whiffs through the 2026 season. When up in the zone, it is nearly unhittable.

The nearly is where the risk comes from with this type of FB; 8 homers allowed, making up 20% of the total hits. It is a flaw of the carry fastball, that when squared up, it provides the lift necessary to give up home runs. In the upper third of the zone this year, the FB allowed a miniscule .228 average but all of his XBH allowed were also there. That tradeoff comes with elite riding fastballs and is not particularly alarming. When placed just above the zone, the FB got a 47% chase rate and 43% whiff. Being

consistent to that above the zone spot will be important long term to sustain success for Sanford. He showcased the ability to land it low and away as well, letting the ride hold the pitch to the bottom third for a sub 50% swing rate. Continuing to weaponize both the above-the-zone fastball and the strike-stealing version at the bottom of the zone would effectively allow Sanford to create two distinct fastball looks without changing grips. 60/70 pitch

The CB is Sanford's primary secondary pitch and is a big 12-6 with elite spin rates in the 96th percentile for NCAA curves and nearly 300 rpm above the big league average. The curve generated a 37% CSW despite just an 11% swinging-strike rate, illustrating how often hitters simply froze against its combination of depth and elite spin. This conviction he showed to land the curve for strikes only helps it play up. It only got swings a quarter of the time, likely due to the spin depth combo it creates and the 17 mph, 40 inches of induced break delta off the FB. Even when swung at in the zone, Sanford's curve allowed a sub .250 avg without an XBH and 72% ground balls. The break is late as well with the curve's approach to the top of the zone being similar to some curve's approach to the bottom of the zone, highlighting just how plus this pitch is. When he located it down and glove-side with 2K, it ended at bats getting a whopping 58% out-of-zone whiff rate. There is not much improvement to look for in the curve besides additional protection as Sanford rounds out his arsenal in the future. 60/60+ pitch

The SL is a pitch that will need sharpening, but it has plus traits in its current iteration. Sanford spins it well getting elite depth and average glove-side, but at 83, the pitch is currently too slow off of the FB and drifts too often into the low 80s instead of the mid 80s. Sanford showed confidence throwing the slider early in counts, with one-third of all sliders coming on 0-0 counts and over 10% opening an inning. He clearly has the confidence to attempt the slider for strikes but he only zoned it 32% of the time with a lot of middle sliders, especially to lefties. To righties, where the slider was featured more, he got it D/A with 10 whiffs. The raw traits are comfortably above average, but improved velocity consistency and more reliable strike throwing would allow the slider to become a true third weapon rather than a complementary pitch. 45/50+ pitch

The CH feels like the biggest ceiling grabber in the arsenal. The pitch is comfortably plus in results, shape, and even above average command, but Sanford only threw it 4% of the time, and just 8% of the time to lefties. In that small sample, he got it down beneath the zone and had an unreal 69% whiff rate and 31% SWSTR and lefties could simply not lay off the pitch. The 20 inches vertical delta coupled with a roughly 10 mph velo delta helps the pitch play up even more. The CH average tilt was 3:15 and he showed the ability to bring the pitch below the 0 line, a rare trait for someone who throws so vertical of a fastball. Increasing the usage should be a priority entering 2027. The pitch already flashes above-average traits and gives Sanford a legitimate weapon against left-handed hitters while making the entire arsenal considerably more difficult to game plan against. 50/60+ pitch